

Desktop computers and laptops

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The word “computer” is mainly associated with desktop and laptop computers. Each has a wide range of uses, but they also have their own pros and cons.

What is a computer?

A computer is an electronic device that manipulates data. It can receive input and perform a sequence of programmed instructions to produce a result. The original digital computers filled entire rooms, and personal computers (PCs) – small, affordable devices that individuals could own and operate – didn’t appear until the 1970s. The PC revolution of the 1970s and 1980s saw an increase in computers with relatively easy-to-use software that brought computers to many homes.

▽ **Home and business**
Nowadays, the majority of homes and businesses use computers for everyday activities. These include communication via email and social media, scheduling via calendars, shopping, and entertainment.



Desktops vs laptops

People who need to do fairly substantial amounts of work may require a computer. Desktop computers are stationary and sit on a desk or table. They operate from a mains power supply, and usually have a separate screen, mouse, and keyboard. They are versatile and cheaper than a similarly powerful laptop. Laptop computers, on the other hand, are portable, battery- or mains-powered, and have an integrated screen or touchscreen, touchpad, and keyboard. They are usually more expensive, and tend to have smaller screens and keyboards.

▷ **Which to choose?**
For most people the choice is based on a combination of factors, such as price, portability, available space, and what the computer is to be used for.

	Pros	Cons
Desktop	Cheaper	Not portable
	More design options	Takes up more space
	Usually more processing power	Harder to set up
Laptop	Portable	More rigidly designed
	Easy to set up	Less versatile
	Takes up less space	More expensive